ARC ARISE · SOUTHERN ENVIRONMENTAL & ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT STRATEGY

SEEDS PARTNER KICKOFF

Planning the Southern Appalachian Greenbelt Corridor together

Week of January 4, 2027
Half day · hybrid · [venue]

Appalachian Conservation Institute
Land Trust of North Alabama
University of Alabama in Huntsville
University of the South, Sewanee

TODAY

WHAT WE LEAVE WITH

01

Roadmap

Sequenced engagement and timetables for all 12 counties

02

Reporting rhythm

Re-engagement plan and the admin process for reporting

03

Trained people

Facilitators ready for stakeholder engagement and planning metrics

04

Media

One shared message and a media calendar with owners

05

Implementation vision

A first picture of what happens after the 18 months

THE REGION

TWELVE COUNTIES, TWO STATES, ONE LANDSCAPE

High-value forests, watersheds and recreation assets on and around the Cumberland Plateau, reached through rural gateway towns.

2 Distressed

4 At-Risk

5 Transitional

1 Competitive

County	ARC FY26 status
Grundy, TN	Distressed
Bledsoe, TN	Distressed
Sequatchie, TN	At-Risk
Warren, TN	At-Risk
DeKalb, TN	At-Risk
Van Buren, TN	At-Risk
Franklin, TN	Transitional
Marion, TN	Transitional
Coffee, TN	Transitional
Marshall, AL	Transitional
Jackson, AL	Transitional
Madison, AL	Competitive

THE VISION

A conservation-centered economy that twelve communities can grow on their own terms

A connected Southern Appalachian Greenbelt Corridor: protected forest blocks, linked trails and thriving gateway towns, planned with the people who live there and ready to compete for implementation funding.

GOALS

WHAT ARC FUNDS US TO DELIVER

ARC Investment Goal 4, Objective 4.3: preserve and expand natural resources to increase outdoor recreation and support sustainable economic growth.

1	12	12	100	50
Feasibility study and greenbelt corridor plan	Communities served	Communities improved (pre/post capacity assessment)	Participants served (sign-in and participation logs)	Participants improved (pre/post evaluation)

DELIVERABLES

FOUR PRODUCTS BY APRIL 2028

Feasibility Study and Greenbelt Corridor Plan

Priority conservation parcels, ecological corridors and nature-based tourism strategies across all 12 counties.

Economic Impact Assessment

Visitor spending, business development and job potential, with an end-user projection tool.

Geo-AI Decision Support System

Ecological data, land prioritization and community input in one platform for local governments and planners.

Community Engagement and Workforce Development Plan

Local priorities, stakeholder commitments and pathways into conservation and outdoor-recreation jobs.

WHO DOES WHAT

FIVE PARTNERS, ONE PLAN

ACI

Lead and fiscal agent

Coordinates partners and ARC reporting; hires and supervises facilitators; leads county workshops; leads final synthesis and rollout.

LTNAL

Engagement and field planning co-lead

Co-leads engagement; designs workshops; brings conservation-land data and landowner relationships.

UAH

Technical and economic analysis lead

Survey design, corridor analysis, Geo-AI decision support, economic assessment; trains facilitators in data collection.

Sewanee

STEAM and workforce lead

STEAM strategy; students in field data and geospatial work; participatory science at workshops.

SCTP

Tourism advisor

Tourism guidance; reviews engagement plans; sounding board for workshops.

UAH TASKS

FIVE TECHNICAL TASKS

Task	What	When	Hand-off to partners
1	Stakeholder consultation and survey design	Oct–Dec 2026	Instruments for facilitators
2	Feasibility study and greenbelt corridor planning	Oct 2026–Sep 2027	Corridor plan drafts to review
3	Geo-AI decision support prototype	Oct 2026–Mar 2028	The live planner
4	Economic impact assessment design	Oct–Dec 2026	Indicators collected at workshops
5	Economic impact projection tool	Mar 2027–Mar 2028	Scenario tool for counties

Tasks 2 and 3 are delivered as one tool: the Greenbelt Corridor Planner.

ENGAGEMENT

HOW WE REACH ALL TWELVE COUNTIES

ACI + LTNAL

Hire and train facilitators

Project goals, engagement methods, STEAM integration, data protocols (UAH trains data collection).

ACI + LTNAL

Focus groups in each state

Large sessions in Alabama and Tennessee to set regional priorities.

ACI + LTNAL

County workshops

Workshops and listening sessions on local priorities, economic conditions, tourism and conservation.

SEWANEE

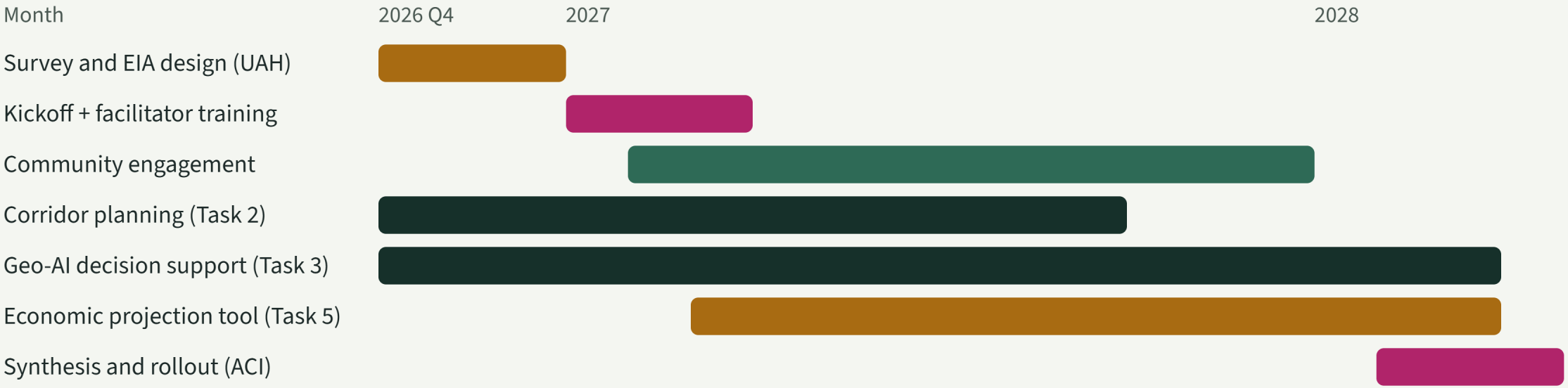
Participatory science

Students and residents collect field data and build skills for natural-resource careers.

Early to late 2027. Exercise 1 sets the order of counties; the training block prepares the people who run them.

TIMELINE

OCTOBER 2026 TO APRIL 2028



WHERE WE START

THE GREENBELT CORRIDOR PLANNER IS LIVE

A web map every partner can open today. It scores land, routes greenbelt corridors along existing trails, and shows who owns the land along the way.

[planner link] · fact sheet in the project repository

Priority scoring

16 criteria on about 3,200 hexagons, including a Geo-AI model of conservation-quality land.

Trail-following corridors

Routes over existing trails, greenways and streets, with every gap that needs new trail listed.

Stakeholder input built in

Survey answers load as weights; residents drop comments on the map.

HOW WE WORK

A PROPOSED RHYTHM TO AGREE TODAY

Meetings

- Core team: every two weeks
- All partners: monthly
- County visits: by engagement wave

Reporting

- ACI reports to ARC as fiscal agent
- Partners feed a shared performance log
- Subaward invoices on an agreed cycle

Shared spaces

- Drive: documents, slides, notes
- GitHub: tools and data
- Kickoff site: one link for everything

Proposals only. Exercise 4 sets the reporting matrix and dates. Please send your GitHub username through the RSVP form.

BEYOND 18 MONTHS

PLANNING THAT LEADS TO PROJECTS

FEB–APR 2028

Pick and match

Name priority implementation projects and match each to a funding source.

MID-2028 TO 2029

Apply and start

Submit proposals, begin early projects where funding lands.

2029 AND BEYOND

Build in phases

Recreation infrastructure, land conservation and workforce programs.

Funding to target: ARC Area Development · USDA Rural Development · U.S. Forest Service · NOAA and NASA Earth science programs · Alabama and Tennessee tourism and conservation programs · foundations and land trusts

TODAY'S AGENDA

Time	Session	Lead	Builds
9:00–9:20	Welcome, introductions, pin your place	ACI	O5
9:20–9:45	The project plan: goals, deliverables, who does what	All	O1
9:45–10:25	Exercise 1 · Build the roadmap	ACI, LTNAL	O1
10:25–10:35	Break		
10:35–10:50	Training I · Stakeholder instruments and planning metrics	UAH	O3
10:50–11:15	Exercise 2 · Rehearse a county workshop	UAH	O3
11:15–11:25	Training II · STEAM and participatory science	Sewanee	O3
11:25–11:40	Exercise 3 · Practice the field protocol	Sewanee	O3
11:40–12:05	Exercise 4 · Reporting and re-engagement	ACI	O2
12:05–12:20	Exercise 5 · Message house and media calendar	ACI, LTNAL	O4
12:20–12:50	Exercise 6 · Postcard from 2030	All	O5
12:50–1:00	Commitments and close	ACI	O1 O2